

Chapter 118-7

Xu Qingzhu nodded to herself, her movements slow, her eyes rolling around, not knowing what she was pondering.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

"Come here," Xu Qingzhu raised her head to look at her, suddenly speaking with a commanding tone.

Liang Shi: "....."

"What is it?" Liang Shi asked as she walked in. "Do you want me to turn off the light for you?"

She happened to walk to the bedside. Her face, just washed, was like white jade porcelain, without a single flaw visible. Standing at Xu Qingzhu's side, she casually pressed off the bedside lamp, then couldn't resist patting Xu Qingzhu's head.

Liang Shi really loved the feel of stroking Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Soft and smooth.

When she petted Xu Qingzhu's hair, Xu Qingzhu's expression would be especially obedient.

Liang Shi coaxed her: "Read for a bit then go to sleep."

Her gentle voice in the quiet room was like honey that wouldn't dissolve.

But Xu Qingzhu made space for her: "Keep me company a bit longer."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi followed her words and sat on the edge of the bed, asking: "Can't sleep?"

"Can you fall asleep?" Xu Qingzhu asked back. "It's only nine o'clock."

Liang Shi: ".....Force myself to sleep."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, closed the book in her hand and set it aside, asking with less than full certainty: "You're leaving for half a month?"

Liang Shi nodded: "This is still on the short side."

She hadn't caught the longing and reluctance in Xu Qingzhu's words.

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "How long is a long one?"

"Some go abroad to film, or go into dense forests—those are generally three months minimum, some over a year. But on average it's three to four months."

"That long," Xu Qingzhu asked. "No weekends? No holidays?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi laughed. Seeing her expression was too serious, she couldn't resist pinching her face.

The gesture was light, carrying a doting quality.

Liang Shi said: "You think it's like working at your company? Filming for one day wastes a day's worth of money. The entire crew has hundreds or thousands of people—the moment the cameras start rolling, money is being spent. It's different from you."

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue: "The office building we bought isn't money? Water and electricity are also money, and the company also has several hundred employees."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Yes, yes, yes," Liang Shi went along with her words. "President Xu makes a valid point, but film crews are generally small budget. Better directors can get bigger sponsors, but at most it's just tens of millions—can't compare to you wealthy and powerful corporate types."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Xu Qingzhu's foot extended from under the covers and kicked at her. Liang Shi immediately pressed it down.

Xu Qingzhu said: "You're insulting me, aren't you?"

Liang Shi: "I wouldn't dare."

"It's that you wouldn't dare," Xu Qingzhu said with certainty. "Not that you wouldn't."

Liang Shi: "Then it's that I wouldn't. How could I insult you?"

Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly: "Your whole face is written with—evil capitalists."

Liang Shi tucked her somewhat cold feet into the covers and covered them properly: "Other people are evil capitalists, but President Xu is a beautiful capitalist. It's different."

"If your crew had investment, could you take time off?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi, suddenly sensing danger, asked: "What for? You want to throw money at me?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She hadn't thought of that originally, but Liang Shi's reaction was so extreme that Xu Qingzhu suddenly felt playful. She nodded: "Yeah, would that work?"

Liang Shi: ".....Just... if you don't want me to go out, I... can compromise. You don't need to spend money."

Xu Qingzhu was stunned for a few seconds after hearing this: "So I should build you a golden house¹? Hide you away?"

"Hide me for how many years?" Liang Shi went along with her words.

Xu Qingzhu asked her back: "How many years do you want to stay?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Seeing the topic getting more and more off track, Liang Shi couldn't help smiling as she ruffled Xu Qingzhu's hair, messing it up with a few strands sticking up.

Liang Shi rubbed her head and said: "President Xu, put away your investor tricks. I just want to film my drama in peace."

"But you're leaving for half a month," Xu Qingzhu said.

That cool voice softened, carrying an indescribable, unclear meaning that made Liang Shi's heart itch.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu, their gazes meeting in the air.

Liang Shi's throat rolled. After a moment, she sighed and opened her arms to her: "Come here for a hug."

Footnote:

¹ Golden house (金屋): Reference to the Chinese idiom "金屋藏娇" (jīn wū cáng jiāo), literally "hiding a beauty in a golden house." It originates from a historical story about Emperor Wu of Han who as a child promised to build a golden house for his cousin if he could marry her. The phrase now refers to keeping a mistress or lover hidden away in luxury.